



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

A MOMENT TO CHERISH FOR INDIAN MEN'S REGU TEAM

India's men's regu team clinched the country's first-ever ISTAF World Cup gold on March 25, 2025, in Patna, defeating Japan 11-15, 15-11, 17-14. The victory, celebrated nationwide, was aided by the absence of powerhouses Malaysia and Thailand due to tournament participation rules. "It helped us. They are the best teams, and we are yet to reach that level," admitted head coach Hemraj.

Bihar secured hosting rights due to its successful track record, sepaktakraw's priority-sport status, and strong backing from the Sepaktakraw Federation of India. The State, traditionally not a sepak takraw hub, now ranks second nationally. "An immediate effect of this success is sepaktakraw's inclusion as a medal sport in the Khelo India Youth Games," said Bihar Sports Authority Director General Raveendran Sankaran. Plans are underway to set up an elite academy.

Despite government support, the sport lacks a structured league or frequent national tournaments. A pre-tournament camp in Thailand was key to India's preparation. With the 2026 Asian Games in sight, the next challenge is sustaining momentum. "There's discussion within the federation about a professional league, and I hope it's now prioritised," Hemraj said.

Saikat Chakraborty